STUDENT SOCIAL RESPONSIBILTY PORTFOLIO

Student Name: AARYAVIR SHAH

Name of the NGO/Organization: AKANKSHA FOUNDATION

Period of Service: 11th September 2025 to 4th February 2026

Name of the SSR Advisor:

SSR ADVISOR REVIEW:
(The SSR Advisor will review and comment on the student's effort, progress and commitment)

Status of Completion of the SSR Service Log: Completed/Incomplete

Remarks by the SSR Coordinator:

The SSR Stages:

For each of the stages, students must write about 120 to 200 words. These need to be supported with pictures, videos or presentations conducted.
For each stage some key terms have been underlined, which will guide in the writing process.
It is necessary to cover all the stages for the portfolio to be complete.

1. **The need in the community:**
    - Students must introduce the NGO/Organisation by giving a brief description of the service that the NGO is providing to the community (its ethos/philosophy/ initiatives/etc.
    - Students identify a need they want to address in the community through their individual service with the NGO/Organisation
    - Students identify their interests, skills and talents to be used in considering opportunities for working with the NGO/Organisation
    - Students could include what appealed to them during the orientation sessions conducted by the NGOs

2. **Planning of the service to be rendered:**
    - Students should mention details about what service actions/activities they planned once they had a clear idea of the needs of the NGO/Organisation they were working
    - Students must also mention details of the guidance they received from their SSR advisors.
    - Students should mention the difficulties faced during this stage
    - Students should mention details of the assistance they received from the NGO/Organisation/other people in planning their activities

3. **Initiation and execution of service:**
    - Students must give details of the activities conducted at the NGO/Organisation
    - Students must mention what worked well and what did not
    - Students must mention the improvisations they needed to carry out for successful implementation of the activities

- Students must clearly mention the number of activity/service sessions they have conducted at the NGO along with details of time period
- In this section students must summarize details that they have mentioned in their Service Log (excel sheets)

4. **Reflection:**

- Students must examine their thoughts, feelings and actions as applied in the SSR context
- Students must make explicit what and how they learned and what they have accomplished
- A thorough evaluation of the benefits of the SSR project for all involved
- Students must provide evidence in the form of plans, videos, or pictures taken during the conduction of the activity/service sessions
- In case you have worked on more than one NGO and green cell initiatives, please add them as well.

SSR Portfolio

1. The Need in the Community

Introducing the Akanksha Foundation

The Akanksha Foundation is a non-profit organization that has been operating in the education sector since 1991. Its goal is to offer children from low-income families in Mumbai and Pune access to quality education that not only imparts academic knowledge but also helps them develop confidence, good values, and essential life skills to achieve their full potential. The foundation supports children through its network of schools and after-school centres, providing them with a nurturing and encouraging learning environment that might otherwise be out of reach.

During my orientation on 11 September 2025, I was introduced to the foundation's vision, teaching approaches, and the expectations for volunteers. I was especially impressed by the warm and inclusive atmosphere, the professional attitude of the staff, and the clear instructions given about my role. The session emphasized the importance of dedication, understanding, and consistency when supporting young learners.

Identifying the Need

Many students at the centre, especially those in Grades 1 to 5, find it difficult to grasp basic ideas in Mathematics and English because they don't get enough help with their studies outside of school. It is important to strengthen these fundamental skills, as they are the foundation for future learning and help build confidence in the classroom.

I thought I could make a difference by helping students develop these basics in a supportive and enjoyable way. I have always enjoyed breaking down concepts into simple terms and working with younger kids. I believed my patience and positive attitude would help me connect with them and make learning more meaningful. The orientation showed me that effective teaching involves more than just giving lessons—it also means inspiring students, boosting their confidence, and fostering a positive classroom environment.

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2. Planning of the Service to be Rendered

After assessing the students' needs, I designed lessons that aimed to improve their fundamental skills in Mathematics and English. In Mathematics, I focused on one-digit addition and subtraction, while in English, I worked on basic reading, pronunciation, vocabulary building, and forming sentences.

Instead of using separate worksheets, I used the students' own notebooks to keep track of corrections, explanations, and practice exercises, making it easier for them to review the material later. I also organized activities that promoted teamwork by pairing students together, enabling more capable learners to assist those who needed extra help.

Before starting my service, my SSR advisor stressed the importance of professionalism, reminding me to be patient and respectful with every child, ensure that all students felt valued and included, and follow safeguarding rules, such as not taking photographs without permission.

One of the biggest challenges during lesson planning was creating activities that catered to students with varying ability levels. Since I was not initially familiar with each child's academic performance, it was hard to develop lessons that worked for everyone. However, the teachers at Akanksha gave me useful feedback on the students' strengths and areas for improvement, and they suggested proven teaching methods, which helped me adjust my plans effectively.

3. Initiation and Execution of Service

During my time at Akanksha, I worked closely with students by teaching fundamental Mathematics topics like adding and subtracting single-digit numbers, as well as helping them improve their reading and English language abilities. I frequently reviewed their notebooks, identifying errors as chances to revisit key concepts, and encouraged students to think for themselves rather than just giving them the right answers.

In addition to teaching, I supported the classroom teachers by helping to keep order, ensuring students stayed involved in lessons, and stepping in whenever needed. To make learning more engaging, I grouped students into small teams where they could work together to solve problems, share ideas, and learn from each other. This teamwork approach was very effective, as it boosted participation and fostered a sense of cooperation.

One challenge I faced was keeping the attention of younger students for long periods. I quickly learned that shorter, more varied activities were far more successful than lengthy explanations. To maintain their focus, I introduced quick oral quizzes, interactive questions, and short problem-solving games between lessons, which greatly improved their concentration and involvement.

Alongside my work at Akanksha, I also contributed to several other community service initiatives. I volunteered at **Happy Place**, assisting in organising an art competition that encouraged creativity among children, contributing **8–10 hours** of service.

Additionally, I spent time with the **Welfare of Stray Dogs (WSD)**, where I interacted with abandoned and injured dogs and cats, walked them, and learnt about the organisation's rescue and rehabilitation efforts through discussions with its representatives.

I am also developing a financial literacy platform where kids are taught with simulated money how to budget their expenses and invest their savings in different financial instruments like SIP and stocks. This way, the kids can get real-life experience and "Practice Money Before it's Real". I hope this can help the underprivileged kids come up in life, as my motto is to make the kids financially literate and face the real world.

All of these activities, carried out between **11th September 2025 and 4th February 2026**, have been recorded in my Service Log.

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4. Reflection

This service experience greatly improved my patience, communication skills, and ability to adjust my teaching approaches to meet the diverse needs of children. One of the most fulfilling moments was seeing a student solve a subtraction problem confidently on their own after struggling with it before. These experiences showed me how consistent encouragement and personalized support can make a real difference in a child's learning process.

Working with the teachers also gave me a better understanding of the effort, preparation, and perseverance needed to manage a classroom effectively on a daily basis. Beyond teaching, I learned the importance of showing empathy, offering support, and creating a safe environment where children feel comfortable expressing themselves and learning from their mistakes.

My visit to the Welfare of Stray Dogs was also a meaningful experience. Seeing the care and attention given to injured and abandoned animals made me realize the importance of compassion and community involvement beyond education. It expanded my view of service and showed me the value of supporting issues that often go unnoticed.

Participating in the Happy Place art competition also helped me develop my organizational, teamwork, and leadership abilities. Organizing events required thoughtful planning, effective communication, and the ability to work well with others to ensure everything went smoothly.

If I had the chance to participate in this service again, I would start volunteering earlier in the academic year so that I could work with the same students for a longer period and track their progress more closely.

Overall, this experience was both valuable and personally enriching. While I hope I contributed positively to the community, I believe the lessons I learned about responsibility, empathy, and service will stay with me long after the program ended.